

Getting Started with Gentoo Linux



This article is a guide to installing Gentoo Linux on a generic x86 system. It is aimed at beginners with average command-line experience.

Which distribution of Linux should I use?" This is one of the common queries among new users and hackers throughout the community. Posting such a question in community forums is never a good idea, since you will most likely end up with heaps of different suggestions. Even in my LUG (Linux User Group), where we have informal GNU/Linux study sessions, we often end up debating which distribution is the best, though we all know that such debates are somewhat pointless.

To choose the right distribution, you will first need a quick brainstorming session

on what you want the system to perform as—either as a desktop system with an X environment, or a server with just the text console (command line). Sometimes you want both, a desktop and a server, or even a router with minimal components.

Gentoo Linux is a source-based ‘meta-distribution’, which means it is capable of functioning as a powerful workstation, desktop system, hardened server, or even a simple router.

Portage is the heart of Gentoo; it acts as the package-management system, as well as the package distribution system. Unlike other package-management systems (such as Yum in